

THE WEIGHT OF QUIET

Written by

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Working title. One continuous shot, no cuts.
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FADE IN:

EXT. LAKE DISTRICT COTTAGE / FELLS - DUSK

Black. Then the grey ridge of mountains against darker sky.

The camera hangs high above a stone cottage. A single downstairs window burns gold.

It begins to descend. Not a fall. A glide. It snakes down through the cold, tilting toward the light the way a thing comes home.

Closer. The window. The sill. It slips through the gap where the pane sits open.

INT. COTTAGE - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Into a quiet room.

A kettle has not long boiled. Two mugs on the side table. One steaming. The other, further along, stone cold. It has been there for hours.

MAYA, 30s, on the sofa, still in her coat, a book face down on her knee that she is not reading. JAMES, 30s, moving about the small kitchen, unhurried, at home in it.

The camera settles a few feet off his shoulder. He doesn't look at it. Something in him eases. A body that has decided it isn't alone.

JAMES

There's a heron on the tarn in the mornings. Same spot. Just stands there for hours.

MAYA

Does it.

JAMES

Doesn't do anything. Just stands.

MAYA

You said we'd talk when we got here.

JAMES

We're talking.

MAYA

About a heron.

He sets a plate on the rack. Picks up the cold mug, the far one, and slides it into line with the other. Squares it. Goes back to the sink. He does not notice he has done it.

Maya watches him do it. She has seen it before. She says nothing.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Come and sit down. Please. Just for a minute.

JAMES
Two seconds.

He wipes a surface that is already clean.

MAYA
That's the second one you've wiped.

JAMES
It's a rental. You don't know who's been in here.

MAYA
(a small laugh, no humour in it)
Right.

She closes the book. Sets it aside. The holiday is over, and it never started.

MAYA (CONT'D)
I moved things around to get these three days. Real things. So we could sit in a room together and be...

She doesn't finish it. He is drying his hands, and drying them, and drying them.

MAYA (CONT'D)
I have been so careful with you. For such a long time. I go around this house like there's someone asleep in the next room.

JAMES
Nobody's asking you to do that.

MAYA
No. You never ask for anything. That's the...

She stops herself. Starts again, quieter, without the edge.

MAYA (CONT'D)
I miss you. That's the whole of it.
I'm allowed to miss you when you're
standing right there.

That reaches him. He comes in. Sits down beside her,
finally. A small victory. She almost lets herself have it.

Then his eyes drift. Past her. Toward the space at the end
of the sofa. A stillness comes over him, like listening.

MAYA (CONT'D)
(soft)
And there you go.

JAMES
I'm here.

MAYA
You did it just then. You went.

JAMES
I didn't go anywhere.

He stands. Restless now. Crosses to the window and opens it.
Cold air moves into the room.

MAYA
It's freezing out.

JAMES
It gets close in here.

MAYA
It does not get close. It is a
stone cottage in November and you
open the windows like you are
letting something out. Or letting
something in.

He doesn't answer that. He looks out at the dark for a
moment too long.

MAYA (CONT'D)
You made two coffees this morning.

JAMES
Don't.

MAYA
Two. I watched you. You made two,
you drank one, you left the other
one on the side to go cold, and you
didn't even--

JAMES
I forgot I'd poured it.

MAYA
You don't forget. You measure the
rice. You have never forgotten
anything in your life.

JAMES
It's a cup of coffee, Maya.

MAYA
It is not a cup of coffee.

A beat. And she hears it. On the surface, it is exactly a
cup of coffee. That is the thing she can never quite hold.
She changes tack.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Look at me.

JAMES
I'm looking at you.

MAYA
For one whole sentence. Start to
finish.

She crosses the room. Takes his face in both her hands.
Turns it to hers.

MAYA (CONT'D)
There. Am I that hard to look at.
Am I.

He lets her hold it. A moment. Then, gently, helplessly, his
eyes slide past her to the space beside them. She feels his
face turn under her hands toward nothing at all.

She lets go like it burned her.

MAYA (CONT'D)
Who is it.

JAMES
There is no one.

MAYA
Then why do I feel like I'm the one
who shouldn't be here. In my own
marriage. There is always a room
you are in that I do not get a key
to.

She is not shouting. It is worse than shouting.

MAYA (CONT'D)

You leave your own eyes. Do you know that. Mid-word, you go somewhere behind your own face, and you leave me talking to the front of it.

The fight goes out of her all at once. What is left is quiet, and it costs her.

MAYA (CONT'D)

You could put it down. You know you could. You could just...

She loses the sentence. Reaches for it again, and it comes out smaller, and truer.

MAYA (CONT'D)

For one minute you could set it down and be here with me. And you won't. And I have stopped believing it's because you can't. I think you're frightened of who you'd be with your hands empty.

JAMES

(barely)

It isn't that simple.

MAYA

It is exactly that simple. That is the part that kills me.

He turns to her. Something breaks loose in him. He crosses the space fast, not gentle, and takes her, and it is a collision more than an embrace. She shoves him hard in the chest, then fists his shirt and hauls him back in. Rage and want with no daylight between them.

She bites his shoulder. Hard. He makes a sound. He holds her by the arms, too tight, his face turned away over her head. His eyes open. Finding the space.

JAMES

(breaking, into her hair)

I am trying. You have no idea how hard I am trying.

MAYA

Trying to stay. You cannot even do that.

His eyes fix on the empty air where the camera hovers. Something goes out of his face.

He lets go of her. Steps back.

MAYA (CONT'D)
What. What is it.

He is not looking at her. He steps back again, into the room, and his hand comes up. Reaching toward the nothing beside him. Palm open. At a height. As if to find a shoulder that should be there.

His fingers an inch from the lens.

And he sees it. What he is doing. The reach. The two mugs. The cold coffee. The open window. Maya. Himself. The empty space. The whole shape of it, all at once, laid out like evidence.

His face comes apart.

JAMES
(barely)
No.

His arm sweeps the side table. The cold mug hits the floor and smashes.

MAYA
(flinching back)
James.

He is not looking at her. He is looking at the empty air. He backs away from it, and it follows him, gentle, closer, not understanding.

JAMES
(low, pleading, to no one
she can see)
Not tonight. Not now. Go. Please.
Go.

MAYA
(barely a whisper)
Who are you talking to.

JAMES
(a roar, ragged, at
nothing at all)
FUCK OFF!

The camera flinches.

Then it BOLTS. A hard rush back, away from him, across the room, over the broken mug, out through the gap in the window.

EXT. COTTAGE / FELLS - CONTINUOUS

Out into the cold and UP. Fast. Climbing hard. The gold window shrinking beneath it.

The mountains. The dark. All that empty country.

It stops, high above the roof. Looks down.

Down at the little lit cottage. Down at the one warm window with the man in it. Small now. Both hands over his face.

And Maya, frozen behind him. Staring at the man she loves shaking at an empty room, a smashed cup at his feet, and nothing there. Nothing at all.

The camera holds in the dark. Tilted down. The way you look back at a place you have just been thrown out of.

The way an intruder looks at a house.

FADE OUT.